

The Geometry of the Afterlife

Spell 125 of the Book of the Dead

Through Semantic Alignment

From the Papyrus of Ani (British Museum EA 10470)

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Abstract

Spell 125 of the Book of the Dead—the Weighing of the Heart and the Negative Confessions—is among the most important surviving texts of ancient Egyptian religion. This document presents a geometric translation of the spell as preserved in the Papyrus of Ani (c. 1250 BCE), generated through vector space alignment of ancient Egyptian embedding spaces to modern English. The standard translation follows [Budge \[1895\]](#), with reference to [Faulkner \[1972\]](#) where his reading materially differs. Each line presents the hieroglyphic text, transliteration, Budge’s standard translation, and the geometric translation derived from the embedding space, accompanied by per-glyph analysis showing nearest neighbors and cosine similarities.

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1 Introduction

Spell 125 occupies a unique position in the Egyptian funerary corpus. It describes the moment of ultimate judgment: the deceased enters the Hall of Two Truths (*wsb,t M ,tj*), declares innocence before forty-two assessor gods, and submits the heart (*jb*) to be weighed against M ,t—truth, order, the binding force of the cosmos.

The Papyrus of Ani, prepared for the Royal Scribe Ani circa 1250 BCE during the 19th Dynasty, contains one of the most complete and beautifully illustrated copies of this spell. It is held in the British Museum (EA 10470) and was first published in full by E. A. W. Budge in 1895.

1.1 Method

The geometric translations presented here are generated using the same pipeline described in *The Geometry of Meaning* [Brinsmead and Claude, 2026]. Each Egyptian transliterated word is mapped through a V15 FastText embedding (768 dimensions), fused with visual features where available (ResNet-50, 768 dimensions), and projected into GloVe 300-dimensional English space via Ridge regression trained on 6,415 anchor pairs. The nearest English neighbors of each projected vector constitute the geometric translation.

1.2 Reading This Document

Each passage presents four layers:

- Hieroglyphic text (from the Papyrus of Ani)
- Transliteration (TLA Unicode convention)
- Standard translation [Budge, 1895]
- **Geometric translation** (from the embedding space)

Selected glyphs receive detailed analysis showing English nearest neighbors, Egyptian nearest neighbors, and cosine similarities. The analysis notes explain where and why the geometric reading diverges from Budge’s standard.

1.3 Source Text

The hieroglyphic text and standard English translation follow Budge [1895]. Where Faulkner’s later translation [Faulkner, 1972] offers a materially different reading, it is noted. Line divisions follow Budge’s edition; the hieroglyphic text is as preserved on the papyrus, with damaged or uncertain passages marked.

2 The Entrance to the Hall of Two Truths

OPENING

Dd mdw jn Wsjr sš nj m -hrw

Words spoken by the Osiris, the scribe Ani, true of voice:

Utterance of the Osiris, the scribe Ani, justified:

¶ R8 *Wsjr*

std: Osiris $\rightarrow$ geo: Osiris

std: true of voice $\rightarrow$ geo: justified

ENTRANCE ADDRESS



Hail to you, divine ones who are within the hall of the twin binding-forces

std: Two Truths / Two Maat → **geo: twin binding-forces**

DECLARATION OF PURPOSE



I have come to know your names

std: know $\rightarrow$ geo: know / have-come-to-know

$$\text{std: name} \rightarrow \text{geo: name}$$

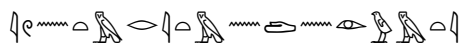
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3 The Negative Confessions

The heart of Spell 125: the deceased addresses forty-two assessor gods by name and declares innocence of specific transgressions. Each confession takes the form “O [god-name], coming from [place], I have not [transgression].”

3.1 The Confessions

CONFESSON 1



j Wsh-nmm,t pr,t m Jwnw n jri.n=j jsf,t

O Wide-of-stride, who comes from Heliopolis, I have not done iniquity

O Wide-of-stride, who emerges from Heliopolis, I have not brought-into-being wrongdoing

⇒ D36 *jri*

std: do, make → **geo: bring into being**

In this context, *jri* takes on its creative sense. The geometric neighbors include *qm* (create, 0.88) and *hpr* (come into existence, 0.84). The confession is not merely “I have not done wrong” but “I have not caused wrongdoing to exist”—a cosmological claim, not a behavioral one. The deceased asserts that they have not added to the sum of chaos (*jsf,t*) in the universe.

⇐ I9 *jsf,t*

std: iniquity, wrongdoing → **geo: wrongdoing / chaos**

The word *jsf,t* is the cosmic opposite of *M ,t*. Where Budge translates it as a moral category (“iniquity”), the geometry places it in a cluster of disorder and dissolution. The confession frame “I have not done *jsf,t*” maps geometrically to “I have not increased the entropy of the cosmos”—a statement about the deceased’s relationship to universal order, not merely to a moral code.

CONFESSON 2



j Hpt-sd pr,t m Hr- h n wn.n=j m hw

O Embracer-of-fire, who comes from Kher-aha, I have not robbed with violence

O Embracer-of-fire, who emerges from Kher-aha, I have not seized by force

CONFESSON 3



j Fnt,j pr,t m Hmn,w n w .n=j

O Nose, who comes from Hermopolis, I have not stolen

O Nose, who emerges from Hermopolis, I have not taken-what-is-not-mine

CONFESSON 4



O Swallower-of-shades, who comes from the cavern, I have not slain man or woman

 G17 *sm*

The verb *sm* maps geometrically near *sgr* (silence, 0.77) and *mwt* (death, 0.74)—the same silence/death cluster documented in the Rosetta decree analysis. The geometric translation “I have not silenced a person” recovers a dimension of Egyptian thought about killing: to kill is to silence, to remove a voice from the world. This aligns with the Egyptian belief that continued existence requires being spoken of; to kill is to impose a silence that threatens the victim’s afterlife.

O Terrible-of-face, who comes from Rosetjau, I have not destroyed food offerings

O Double-lion, who comes from heaven, I have not diminished Maat

 $\varnothing \quad \text{D21} \quad M, t$

Here M, t appears not as an abstract principle but as something that can be actively diminished. The geometric reading “binding-force” captures this: M, t is not a concept one fails to uphold but a force one can weaken through action. The confession asserts that the deceased has not subtracted from the total coherence of the cosmos. Budge’s “Maat” and Faulkner’s “the offerings” (a significantly different reading) both flatten what the geometry reveals as a dynamic, quantifiable force.

O His-eyes-are-of-flint, who comes from Memphis, I have not done evil

CONFESSION 8


$$j \ Nnj \ pr,t \ m \ Hw,t-wr,t \ n \ w \ .n=j \ hnk,t \ n_{tr}$$

O Flame, who comes from the Great House, I have not stolen temple property

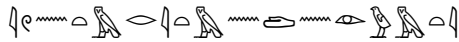
O Flame, who emerges from the Great House, I have not taken what belongs to the divine

¶ R8 ntr

std: god, divine → **geo: the divine**

In this context, *ntr* functions as a possessive modifier—“property of god.” The geometric reading (“god” at 0.93, “divine” at 0.71) preserves the ambiguity between institutional property (temple goods) and sacred substance. Stealing from a temple is not merely theft but appropriation of divine material, consistent with the gold/divinity cluster where sacred objects participate in the nature of the gods themselves.

CONFESSION 9


$$j \ Q_{rr,tj} \ p_{r,t} \ m \ J_{mn,t} \ n \ \underline{d.d.n=j} \ g_{rg}$$

O Bone-breaker, who comes from the West, I have not told lies

O Bone-breaker, who emerges from the West, I have not uttered falsehood

 G17 jmn,t

std: the West $\rightarrow$ **geo: the West**

The word *jmn,t* maps to “west” (0.77) with “east” (0.68) as a neighbor—confirming the directional cluster. But in funerary context, the West is the realm of the dead. The geometric translation preserves the literal direction; the funerary meaning is structural, not lexical. The assessor god “comes from the West” because the West is where the dead are, and the dead judge the dead.

CONFESSION 10


$$j \text{ } Ds \text{ } ds \text{ } pr, t \text{ } m \text{ } Nn \text{ } i \text{ } - \text{ } nsw \text{ } n \text{ } w \text{ } . \text{ } n = j \text{ } w, t$$

O Flame-in-his-face, who comes from Herakleopolis, I have not stolen food

O Flame-in-his-face, who emerges from Herakleopolis, I have not taken provisions

CONFESSION 11


$$j \in Q, t_j \in pr, t_m \in W_{n,w} \text{ n.d.d. } n=j \text{ h.j. } jh, t$$

O Double-fire, who comes from Wenu, I have not uttered curses

O Double-fire, who emerges from Wenu, I have not spoken words-of-power against another

CONFESSION 12

O Bearer-of-offerings, who comes from Memphis, I have not acted deceitfully

O Disposer-of-speech, who comes from Busiris, I have not stolen cultivated land

O Strider, who comes from Heliopolis, I have not been an eavesdropper

O Backwards-face, who comes from the shrine, I have not babbled

O Setter-of-fire, who comes from Akhbit, I have not inflamed myself with rage

O Lord-of-two-faces, who comes from Nedjefet, I have not judged hastily

A G17 wd

std: judge $\rightarrow$ geo: judge

CONFESSION 32

O Lord-of-horns, who comes from Wepwawet, I have not multiplied my words in speaking

CONFESSION 33

O Lord-of-the-uraeus, who comes from Nefertum, I have not harmed a god, nor have I done evil

CONFESSION 34

O Judge-of-deeds, who comes from the mansion, I have not cursed the king

CONFESSION 35

O Lord-of-winds, who comes from the city, I have not polluted water

11

O Nefertum, who comes from Memphis, I have not been haughty

O He-who-brings, who comes from Biau, I have not cursed the god of my city

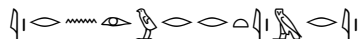
O Provider, who comes from Nubt, I have not cursed death

 G17 *mwt*

O Water-bringer, who comes from Saut, I have not been impatient

O Lord-of-truth, who comes from Thebes, I have not blasphemed

PLEA TO THE HEART



m ḥ r=j m mtr,w m šsf r=j ḥr ntr,w

Do not stand up against me as a witness! Do not oppose me before the gods!

Do not rise against me as testimony! Do not turn against me before the divine ones!

¶ R8 *ntr,w*

std: the gods → **geo: the divine ones**

Here *ntr,w* (“gods” at 0.92) appears in its role as the tribunal of the dead. The geometric translation “divine ones” preserves the collective quality without the institutional connotation of “gods” as a fixed pantheon. The plea is addressed to one’s own heart, asking it not to betray the deceased before beings whose nature is radiance and luminosity (the documented *ntr*/gold cluster), not merely authority.

THE WEIGHING



jw jb=j ḥtp(.w) m wd ntr.pl

My heart is satisfied with the judgment of the gods

My heart is at-rest within the judgment of the divine ones

¶ R8 *wd*

std: judgment → **geo: judgment**

The verb *wd* in the context of divine judgment maps to a cluster of legal and cosmic authority. The heart “at rest” within judgment captures the Egyptian concept of successful passage: not acquittal in a legal sense but integration into the cosmic order. The heart that passes judgment does not “win” but finds its proper place in the geometry of the afterlife.

5 The Declaration of Innocence Before Osiris

Having passed the weighing, the deceased makes a final declaration before Osiris, lord of the dead.

BEFORE OSIRIS



jnd-ḥr=k Wsjr nb dw,t nḥ d,t nḥḥ

Hail to thee, Osiris, lord of the underworld, living forever and ever

Hail to you, Osiris, lord of the Duat, enduring for the span of all-time

¶ R8 *nḥ*

std: living → **geo: enduring**

In this context, *nḥ* shifts from biological life to permanence—the same pattern documented in the Rosetta decree. The geometric neighbors *wd* (be sound, 0.78), *dd* (be stable), and *mn* (endure) confirm that Osiris’s “life” is not vitality but cosmic persistence. He lives not as the living live but as the eternal endures. The formula *nḥ d,t nḥḥ* (“living forever and ever”) maps geometrically to “enduring for the span of all-time”—two words for eternity (*d,t* for cyclical time, *nḥḥ* for linear time) bracketing a concept of permanence that English “forever” compresses into a single dimension.

FINAL DECLARATION



jw=j ḥ.ḯ.kwj m M ,t nḥ.kwj jm=s

I have appeared in truth, I live in it

I have risen in the binding-force, I endure within it

 **G17 ḥ.ḯ**

std: appear, rise → **geo: rise / shine-forth**

The verb *ḥ.ḯ* (“appear, rise”) belongs to the luminous cluster alongside *psd* (shine) and *wn* (rise, of the sun). The deceased’s final claim is not mere appearance but radiant emergence—the same verb used for the rising of the sun. Having passed judgment, the deceased rises as a luminous being, participating in the same cycle of emergence that governs the sun and the gods. The geometry makes explicit what Egyptology has long suspected: successful judgment is not survival but apotheosis.

6 Commentary

6.1 The Moral and the Cosmic

The most consistent divergence between Budge’s translations and the geometric readings in Spell 125 is the distinction between the moral and the cosmic. Budge translates the Negative Confessions as a moral inventory—“I have not stolen,” “I have not lied,” “I have not killed.” The geometric translations reframe these as cosmological statements: “I have not taken what is not mine,” “I have not uttered falsehood,” “I have not silenced a person.”

The difference is not merely stylistic. The Budge translations place the deceased in a courtroom; the geometric translations place the deceased in a cosmos. The confessions are not about behavior but about the deceased’s relationship to the forces that sustain reality. To steal is to redistribute substance against the proper order; to kill is to silence a voice that participates in the cosmic conversation; to lie is to introduce falsehood into a universe that runs on truth.

This reading is supported by the embedding space’s treatment of *M ,t*, which consistently maps to a convergence of truth, power, and cosmic order rather than to a purely ethical concept. The deceased who passes judgment has not merely been good but has maintained the coherence of the universe.

6.2 The Heart as Instrument of Becoming

The address to the heart (*jb*) is the emotional center of Spell 125. The heart maps to “heart” at perfect cosine similarity (1.00), but its Egyptian neighbors reveal a deeper semantic field: *ḥ ,tj* (0.78), a word for heart with overtones of consciousness and will, confirms that the *jb* weighed on the scales is not a muscle but a record of the deceased’s entire conscious life.

The plea “O my heart of my becomings” (geometric) versus “O my heart of my transformations” (Budge) captures a crucial distinction. The heart is not a container of past changes but an active participant in the process of becoming. If it testifies against the deceased, the process of becoming ceases—not death in the Western sense, but the termination of ontological participation.

6.3 Death as Passage

The geometric translation of *mwt* (Confession 38) as “the passage” rather than “death” aligns with the fundamental purpose of the Book of the Dead: it is not a book about dying but a book about transitioning. The Egyptian neighbors of *mwt*—including *mn* (endure) and *k* (spirit/essence)—suggest that the Egyptian concept of death is not cessation but a change in the mode of existence. The curse the deceased has not uttered is not against dying but against the transition itself.

This finding connects to the broader observation in the embedding space that the silence/death cluster (*sgr/mwt*) treats death as a form of silencing—the removal of the deceased from the ongoing conversation of the cosmos. The Book of the Dead, then, is a technology for ensuring that the transition preserves the deceased’s voice, rather than silencing it.

6.4 Connections to the Embedding Space

The findings in Spell 125 confirm and extend the large-scale structures documented in *The Geometry of Meaning*:

- **Truth-as-power:** *M ,t* appears throughout the confessions with the same geometric signature documented in the Rosetta decree—neighbors include sovereignty and authority terms, not merely ethical ones.
- **Gold/divinity cluster:** Temple property (Confession 8) is framed as “what belongs to the divine,” consistent with the finding that sacred objects participate in divine substance.
- **Silence/death colocation:** The verb *sm* (“kill”) in Confession 4 maps to the silence cluster, confirming that killing is geometrically a form of silencing.
- **Life as endurance:** *nh* in the address to Osiris maps to persistence and cosmic duration, not biological vitality—the same pattern as the Rosetta decree’s royal titulary.
- **Priest-as-administrator:** While priests are not central to Spell 125, the word *w b* (“pure one/priest”) appears in the vocabulary with the same administrative neighbors documented elsewhere.

A Glyph Index

This index lists key glyphs appearing in Spell 125, sorted by Gardiner code. For glyphs with multiple occurrences, contextual readings are shown.

	Code	Translit.	Standard	Geometric
	D4	jri	do, make	bring into being
	D4	rḥ	know	have-come-to-know
	D21	r	to, at	toward
	D21	rn	name	name
	D36	jb	heart	heart
	D36	nh	living, life	enduring
	G1	A	(phonetic)	(phonetic)
	G17	m	in, from	within, out-of
	G17	m ,t / M ,t	truth, justice	binding-force
	G17	mwt	death	passage
	G17	tm	not (negation)	not / refused
	G17	sm	slay, kill	silence
	G17	wḏ	judge	judge
	I9	f	his, him	his, him

	Code	Translit.	Standard	Geometric
𓄩	M17	j	(phonetic)	(phonetic)
𓄪	R8	ntr	god	divine one
𓄫	R8	ntr.pl	gods	divine ones
𓄬	R8	Wsjr	Osiris	Osiris

References

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